

Victor Gomes

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Academic Positions

Postdoctoral Researcher, Department of Psychology

HARVARD UNIVERSITY

- Mentors: Jesse Snedeker and Erika Bergelson

Cambridge, MA

September 2024 -

Education

University of Pennsylvania

PHD PROGRAM IN PSYCHOLOGY

- Dissertation: *How to Learn Nothing: Negator Learning as a Mapping Problem*
- Advisor: John Trueswell

Philadelphia, PA

Aug. 2019 - May 2024

University of Pennsylvania

M.S. IN PSYCHOLOGY

Philadelphia, PA

2021

Swarthmore College

B.A. IN PSYCHOLOGY AND COGNITIVE SCIENCE, HIGH HONORS

Swarthmore, PA

Aug. 2013 - May. 2017

Honors & Awards

2021	Paula Menyuk Award , Boston University Conference on Language Development
2020	Mellon Graduate Fellow , Andrew W. Mellon Foundation
2019	Fontaine fellow , Penn Fontaine Fellowship Program
2017	High honors in Cognitive Science , Swarthmore College
2014-2017	HHMI Summer Research Funding , Howard Hughes Medical Institute
2015	Sigma Xi induction , Sigma Xi
2013	Questbridge Scholar , Questbridge

Publications

Gomes, V., Huh, Y., Yun, H., & Trueswell, J. (2026), Failure is always an option: Event failures serve as minimal discourse contexts for early negator use and inference. *Cognition*, 267, 106342.

LaTourrette, A., **Gomes, V.**, Tangen, K., & Trueswell, J. (2025), The development of polyseme learning under uncertainty. *Proceedings of the Annual Meeting of the Cognitive Science Society*, 47.

Gomes, V. (2024), *How to Learn Nothing: Negator Learning as a Mapping Problem* (Doctoral dissertation, University of Pennsylvania)

Gomes, V. (2024), Whither Developmental Psycholinguistics? *Language Development Research*, 5(1), 144—187. <http://doi.org/10.34842/gomesllm>.

Gomes, V. and Doherty, R. and Smits, D. and Goldin-Meadow, S. and Trueswell, J.C. and Feiman, R. (2023), It's not just what we don't know: The mapping problem in the acquisition of negation. *Cognitive Psychology*, 145, 101592. 10.1016/j.cogpsych.2023.101592.

de Carvalho, A. and **Gomes, V.** and Trueswell, J. (2022), English-learning preschoolers can correctly parse and interpret negative sentences to guide their interpretations of novel noun and verb meanings in the acquisition of negation. *Language Acquisition*.

Knowlton, T. and **Gomes, V.** (2022), Linguistic and non-linguistic cues to acquiring the strong distributivity of *each*. *Proceedings of the Linguistic Society of America* (Vol. 7).

Gomes, V. and Huh, Y. and Trueswell, J. (2020), Not what you expect: The relationship between violation of expectation and negation in the acquisition of negation. *Proceedings of the 42nd Annual Conference*

Gomes, V. and de Carvalho, A. (2019), "Look up!" Using easy words to explain how we learn hard words and other aspects of language, an interview with Lila Gleitman. *Revista Linguística*, 14(3), 12-20.

Conference Talks

Gomes, V., Huh, Y., Yun, H., Trueswell, J. (2024), Failures succeed in affirming negation: Event perception & negator learning. Talk presented at the *49th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD)*.

Gomes, V., Knowlton, T., Papafragou, A., Trueswell, J. (2022), Differentiating Universal Quantifiers by Differentiating their Domains? Talk presented at the *47th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD)*.

Knowlton, T. and **Gomes, V.** (2022), Linguistic and non-linguistic cues to acquiring the strong distributivity of *each*. Talk presented at the *Linguistic Society of America (LSA) Annual Meeting*.

Gomes, V., Huh, Y., Goldin-Meadow, S., Feiman, R., and Trueswell, J. (2021), Not as hard as it looks? Linguistic, and not conceptual, ability drives negation acquisition, Talk presented at the *46th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development (BUCLD)*.

de Carvalho, A, **Gomes, V.**, and Trueswell, J. (2021), English-learning preschoolers use negative sentences to constrain novel word meanings of expectation and negation. Talk presented at the *34th Annual CUNY Conference on Human Sentence Processing*.

Gomes, V., Huh, Y. and Trueswell, J. (2020), Not what you expect: The relationship between violation of expectation and negation. Talk presented at the *42nd Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

Conference Posters

Gomes, V., Smolyar, I., Tangen, K., & LaTourrette, A. (2025), The development of polyseme learning under uncertainty. Poster to be presented at the *50th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development*.

Novak, D., **Gomes, V.**, Coppola, M., Snedeker, J., & Kocab, A. (2025), The emergence of negation in Nicaraguan homesign systems. Poster to be presented at the *50th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development*.

LaTourrette, A., **Gomes, V.**, Tangen, K., & Trueswell, J. (2025), The development of polyseme learning under uncertainty. Poster presented at the *47th Annual Conference of the Cognitive Science Society*.

LaTourrette, A., **Gomes, V.**, Tangen, K., & Trueswell, J. (2024). Similarity is an uneven guide to meaning: The development of cross-situational polyseme learning. Poster presented at *The California Meeting on Psycholinguistics*.

Gomes, V., Huh, Y., Yun, H., and Trueswell, J. (2024), Failure teaches success: Linking real-time event processing & production with negation. Poster to be presented at the *37th Annual Conference on Human Sentence Processing*.

Gomes, V., LaTourrette, A., Tangen, K., and Trueswell, J. (2023), Similarity is an uneven guide to meaning: Developmental differences in cross-situational polyseme learning. Poster presented at the *48th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development*.

Gomes, V., Doherty, R., Smiths, D, Goldin-Meadow, S., Trueswell, J., and Feiman, R. (2023), It's not just what we don't know: The mapping problem in the acquisition of negation. Poster presented at the *49th Annual Meeting of the Society for Philosophy and Psychology*.

Gomes, V. (2023), How to think negative thoughts (to learn negators with). Poster presented at *9th meeting of the Mid-Atlantic Colloquium of Studies in Meaning*.

Gomes, V., Goldin-Meadow, S., Trueswell, J., and Feiman, R. (2020), Observing negation: Artificial and Naturalistic Human Simulation Paradigms. Poster presented at the *45th Annual Boston University Conference on Language Development*.

Invited Talks

- Gomes, V.** (Feb. 2, 2025), More senses, more problems: The development of polyseme learning under uncertainty. *Language and Cognition Colloquia, Harvard University.*
- Gomes, V.** (April 5, 2024), What sorts of violations of expectations lead to negation? *Cesana-Arlotti Lab, Yale University.*
- Gomes, V.** (Oct. 2, 2023), Is there nothing in your head? What word learning has to do with observation. *Firestone Lab, Johns Hopkins University.*
- Gomes, V.** (June 3, 2023), It's not just what we don't know: The mapping problem in the acquisition of negation. *Talk given to LaPsyDÉ.*
- Gomes, V.** (March 26, 2020), Not as hard as it looks? *Integrated Language Science and Technology Seminar at the University of Pennsylvania.*

Other Experience

RESEARCH

- University of Pennsylvania Language Learning Lab** *Philadelphia, PA*
RESEARCH SPECIALIST & LABORATORY MANAGER
• PIs: John Trueswell & Lila Gleitman
Apr. 2018 – Aug. 2019
- Swarthmore College EEG Lab** *Swarthmore, PA*
RESEARCH ASSISTANT
• PIs: Les Sikos & Amanda Elam
Feb. 2015 – May. 2017
- Swarthmore Psycholinguistics Lab** *Swarthmore, PA*
RESEARCH ASSISTANT AND THESIS STUDENT
• PI: Daniel Grodner
May. 2015 – May. 2017
- Swarthmore College Neurobehavioral Psychopharmacology Lab** *Swarthmore, PA*
HEAD UNDERGRADUATE RESEARCHER
• PI: Allen Schneider
Aug. 2013 – May. 2017

EDUCATION AND COMMUNICATION

- Lila R. Gleitman Undergraduate Summer Program in Interdisciplinary Mind & Brain Studies (mindCORE)** *Philadelphia, PA*
ASSISTANT DIRECTOR
Summers 2020-Fall 2023
- College of Physicians, Mütter Museum** *Philadelphia, PA*
OUT4STEM PROGRAM COORDINATOR
Nov. 2018 – 2023
- Nautilus Magazine** *New York, NY*
EDITORIAL INTERN
Aug. 2017 – May. 2018

Teaching

- University of Delaware, Language and Cognitive Science** *Newark, DE*
GUEST LECTURER
• LING890: Studies in Linguistics, Dr. Hafri (Fall 2023 & 2024)
– Guest seminar on AI ethics
– Guest lecture on word learning and observation
• LING444: First Language Development, Dr. Beltrama (Fall 2024)
– Guest lecture on word learning
• CGSC170: Introduction to Cognitive Science, Dr. Knowlton (Spring 2025)
– Guest lecture on contemporary AI approaches and ethics
- University of Pennsylvania, Psychology Department** *Philadelphia, PA*
GUEST LECTURER
• PSYC1777: Introduction to Developmental Psychology, Dr. Brannon (Fall 2018)
– Guest lecture on Syntactic Development
• LING0750: Language & Thought (Spring 2021 & 2022, Fall 2023), Dr. Trueswell
– Guest lectures on Bilingualism and Sign Language

University of Pennsylvania, Psychology Department

Philadelphia, PA

TEACHING ASSISTANT

Sept. 2018 - 2023

- PSYC1777: Introduction to Developmental Psychology (Fall 2018)
- PSYC1340: Introduction to Perception (Fall 2020)
 - Designing materials
 - Weekly two-hour-long recitation
- LING0750: Language & Thought (Spring 2021 & 2022, Fall 2023)
- COGS1001: Introduction to Cognitive Science (Fall 2021)
 - Designing materials
 - Weekly hour-long recitation
- PSYC1440: Social Psychology (Spring 2023)
 - Designing materials

University of Pennsylvania, mindCORE

Philadelphia, PA

ASSISTANT DIRECTOR

Summers 2020 - 2023

- Designing and running week-long "coding for experiments" bootcamp (R, Python)
- Designing 10-week summer seminar on topics in cognitive science (perception, language, emotions, social reasoning, and neuroscience)
- Leading and facilitating seminar discussions
- Teaching research poster design and presentation skills

College of Physicians, Mütter Museum

Philadelphia, PA

PROGRAM COORDINATOR

Nov. 2018 - 2023

- Designing curricula for year-long afterschool program
- Designing and giving talks, labs, and project-based workshops
- Assistance and mentoring in college prep
- Examples of talks and workshops:
 - Introduction to Coding
 - * Introduction to general compsci concepts and Python. Students make simple dialogue-tree chat & a car with Lego Mindstorms.
 - The Science of Sound
 - * Learning how we perceive sound with the help of a synthesizer, theremin, and drum machine.
 - The Scientific Method: Science & Trust
 - * Through the lens of alchemy (and counterfeiting), the scientific method is introduced as a standard system for applying skepticism.
 - What is Linguistics?
 - * Starting with sound & working up to meaning, we survey different ways language & communication are researched scientifically.
 - The Great Verb Game
 - * Game-based introduction to psycholinguistics research. Students learn about challenges different words pose to language learners.
 - Sociolinguistics: Language & Identity
 - * How does how we identify shape how we speak, and vice-versa? We discuss how language differences arise, with a focus on Philly.
 - Behind "the Algorithm"
 - * We explore how machine learning shapes what we see online, as well as its limitations and how it can recreate existing biases.
 - Introduction to Interview Skills for Journalism
 - * A series of sessions on how to conduct interviews, from research to practicing interpersonal skills key to interviewing.

Committees

2019-2021	Organizer , Integrated Language Sciences & Technology (ILST) Seminar
2019-2024.	Student Representative , mindCORE Education Committee
2021-2023	Member , (Ad-Hoc) Diversity, Equity, Inclusion & Access Committee, Mütter Museum College of Physicians
2023	Founding Co-Chair , Diversity, Equity, Inclusion & Access Committee, College of Physicians